

Dvar Torah Outline — Lulav on Shabbat: Safek Yom, Gezeirot Chazal, and How Shabbat Itself Replaces the Spiritual “Work” of Lulav

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman examines the Mishnah in Sukkah that describes the mitzvah of lulav as “six and seven” days, and uses it to explore why Chazal sometimes suspend even a Torah-level mitzvah when it coincides with shabbat. He explains the role of *חוק לארץ* and *ספקא דיומא* and how that uncertainty ends up shaping practice even in *ארץ ישראל*. Moving beyond the technical concern of carrying, Rabbi Shulman argues that certain mitzvot (שופר, לולב, מגילה) can pull a person out of a shabbat state of *מנוחה*, and he frames shabbat as possessing inner spiritual capacities that can “do the job” those mitzvot would otherwise do.

I. Setting up the Mishnah: “lulav is six and seven”

A. The calendar setup: when Rosh Hashanah is on shabbat, Sukkot day 1 is also on shabbat

- Rabbi Shulman notes the fixed relationship: if *ראש השנה* falls on *שבת*, then *יום טוב ראשון של סוכות* also falls on *שבת* (14 days later).

B. Mishnah’s language: sometimes six days, sometimes seven

- Rabbi Shulman references the Mishnah’s rule: the mitzvah of lulav is *ששה ושבעה*—either six days or seven days—depending on when shabbat falls during Sukkot.
- If shabbat falls on days **2–7**, lulav is not taken that day → **six** days total.
- If shabbat falls on **day 1**, the Mishnah’s model implies **seven** days (because day 1 is different).

C. Why day 1 is different: Torah obligation everywhere vs. later days

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Gemara’s distinction:
 - Day 1 is a universal *מצוה דאורייתא* for all Jews everywhere (based on the Torah’s “ביום הראשון” framing).
 - Days 2–7 are *דאורייתא* only in *בית המקדש / ירושלים* (and outside is at most rabbinic).

- Historical layer:
 - The practice of taking lulav all seven days everywhere today is **זכר לחורבן**, enacted by **רבן יוחנן בן זכאי**.

D. The sharp question in the Gemara: why cancel even in Jerusalem on later days?

- Rabbi Shulman highlights the Mishnah/Gemara tension:
 - If in **ירושלים** the later days are still **דאורייתא**, why should shabbat cancel lulav there?
- The Gemara's answer as Rabbi Shulman presents it:
 - Day 1 is uniquely weighty because it obligates **all** of **כלל ישראל**.
 - Since later days are not universally binding, Chazal can tell even **ירושלים** not to take lulav on shabbat then.

II. This year's "should-be" outcome: lulav on shabbat—until two curveballs (7:01)

A. The expectation: day 1 on shabbat should not be pushed off

- Rabbi Shulman states the straightforward inference:
 - If shabbat is on **day 1**, the lulav should not be canceled—this is the prime **דאורייתא** day.

B. Curveball #1: **חוץ לארץ** in **ספקא דיומא**

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - In **חוץ לארץ**, two days of Yom Tov are kept due to **ספקא דיומא** (historically: uncertainty when the Beit Din declared the month).
 - Even after calendar standardization, the Gemara's instruction remains: **"מנהג אבותינו בדינים"**—keep the ancestral practice.
- Result:
 - Because day 1 might be day 2 (and shabbat complicates it), lulav is not taken on that shabbat in the diaspora.

C. Curveball #2: the diaspora practice affects **ארץ ישראל** too

- Rabbi Shulman reports the Gemara's conclusion:
 - Even **בני חוץ לארץ** do not take lulav on that shabbat, **because of בני חוץ לארץ**.
- Rabbi Shulman flags the surprise:
 - A **מנהג**/uncertainty outside the Land ends up restricting practice inside the Land.

III. Are Chazal “out to deprive us”? The missing asmachta for lulav (11:00)

A. Contrast to shofar on shabbat: there is an asmachta there

- Rabbi Shulman recalls the previous discussion about not blowing shofar on shabbat:
 - The Gemara brings an asmachta from the Torah's phrasing "זכרון תרועה"—a “remembrance” rather than an actual blowing—when it coincides with rest (shabbat-like framing).
- That asmachta provides a “hint” that supports the rabbinic suspension.

B. Lulav has no such Torah hint—so why so many restrictions?

- Rabbi Shulman argues:
 - By lulav, there is no comparable asmachta suggesting “don't take lulav on shabbat.”
- He notes an additional layer discussed in the room:
 - Perhaps one might frame lulav as מוקצה, but Rabbi Shulman indicates that (per the Rishonim discussion alluded to) this is not a satisfying explanation for such a sweeping prohibition.

C. Reframing the issue: it's not one concern, it's a broader principle

- Rabbi Shulman begins moving from “technical” to “conceptual”:
 - The repeated pattern suggests something deeper than a narrow local concern.

IV. The “carrying” decree and the earlier Amoraim: not really a massive machloket (14:30)

A. Recalling the core gezeirah: “lest one carry four amot”

- Rabbi Shulman names the familiar rationale applied to these mitzvot:
 - גזרה שמא יעבירו ארבע אמות ברשות הרבים.

B. רבי יוסי and “טרוד במצוה פטור”

- Rabbi Shulman cites רבי יוסי's principle:
 - If someone mistakenly carries while preoccupied with performing the mitzvah, he is פטור (exempt from a korban), due to being טרוד במצוה.

- Rabbi Shulman underscores the implication:
 - Even if the violation would not generate full liability, Chazal still enacted the decree—heightening the question of what’s really at stake.

C. How earlier Amoraim would read the lulav sugya

- Rabbi Shulman asks:
 - If some Amoraim emphasized asmachta by shofar, what do they do with the lulav Mishnah where the Gemara foregrounds the carrying concern?
 - His conclusion:
 - The “asmachta vs. carrying” framing is not a deep ideological dispute; rather, all agree to the underlying principle, and the disagreement is more about formulation/technical framing.
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V. A three-mitzvah pattern: shabbat pushes off shofar, lulav, and megillah (18:34)

A. Identifying the trio

- Rabbi Shulman lists three mitzvot that can be suspended on shabbat under the same decree-logic:
 1. שופר
 2. לולב
 3. מגילה

B. Why these and not “any mitzvah”?

- Rabbi Shulman stresses:
 - This isn’t a blanket rule about mitzvot.
 - These mitzvot share a quality that can conflict with shabbat’s essence.
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VI. Why lulav can be “not shabbatdik”: lulav as weaponry and spiritual conflict (19:00)

A. Lulav visually and midrashically resembles a sword

- Rabbi Shulman notes a common observation:
 - The lulav looks like a **sword**.

B. Gemara Sukkah 38a: a “stabbing” motion against the Satan

- Rabbi Shulman paraphrases the Gemara:
 - רב אחא בר יעקב would move the lulav in a stabbing motion, declaring it an “arrow in the eyes of the שטן.”
 - The Gemara advises: do the motion, but avoid verbalizing the provocation (to avoid arousing judgment).

C. Midrashic framing: lulav as “weapons of war”

- Rabbi Shulman cites Midrashim:
 - Lulav and the four species are portrayed as **weapons** through which Israel “wins” in judgment/battle.
 - The image: those leaving a “court/battle” waving lulav are the victors.

D. Shaking lulav as active spiritual defense

- Rabbi Shulman references the Gemara’s purpose:
 - The shaking is לעצור רוחות וטללים רעים—to stop harmful winds/dews.
 - Conceptual consequence:
 - Lulav is about fighting forces of negativity; shabbat is about מנוחה and completion.
 - That “combat posture” can be fundamentally at odds with shabbat’s tranquility.
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VII. Why the practice differs in גלות vs. ארץ ישראל: מנוחה (23:00) undermines exile

A. If everyone lived in Israel, the Gemara implies lulav on shabbat would be possible

- Rabbi Shulman notes:
 - The Gemara’s logic implies a world where (absent diaspora complications) lulav on shabbat day 1 could proceed.

B. Galut as the opposite of tranquility: Rabbi Shulman’s איכה prooftext

- Rabbi Shulman quotes the opening of איכה to describe exile’s lack of rest:
 - “גִּלְתָּהּ יְהוּדָה מֵעֲנִי וּמִרֵּב עֲבָדָה הִיא יִשְׁכָּה בְּגוֹיִם לֹא מִצָּאָה מְנוּחָה”
 (“Judah has gone into exile from affliction and from great labor; she dwells among the nations; she has found no rest.”)

C. Midrashic thesis: true shabbat-keeping and exile cannot coexist

- Rabbi Shulman invokes a well-known Midrashic idea:
 - If Israel truly finds מנוחה through shabbat, that itself undoes exile.
 - The motif: if Israel would keep one shabbat fully, מיד נגאלין—redemption would come immediately.

D. The “carrying concern” as סיבה more than סימן

- Rabbi Shulman reframes the rabbinic fear of carrying:
 - It is often a **sign** that the mitzvah-performance pulls one out of the shabbat mindset.
 - In galut, people are already “barely holding on” to shabbat; introducing a mitzvah framed as spiritual battle can tip them into weekday/action mode.
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VIII. Shabbat can “do the job” of lulav: three levels (שבת, כלה, מלכה (26:30))

A. Rabbi Shulman’s core claim: shabbat substitutes for what these mitzvot accomplish

- Rabbi Shulman returns to the theme used by shofar:
 - Certain mitzvot are suspended because shabbat itself can accomplish their inner spiritual goals.

B. Three names of shabbat and their inner structure

- Rabbi Shulman presents a three-part model:
 - שבת
 - כלה (bride)
 - מלכה (queen)
- He explains these as three modes:
 1. “Shabbat” as the highest, transcendent realm of rest.
 2. “Kallah” as relationship/connection to something higher.
 3. “Malkah” as elevated existence within this world, transformed by that connection.

C. Correspondence to the three shabbat meals (in kabbalistic framing)

- Rabbi Shulman aligns the model with the three meals:
 - Friday night associates with מלכות (noted via the Arizal’s traditions, including אסדר לסעודתא and חקל תפוחין).

- Shabbat day is the highest revelation (“the shabbat of shabbat”).
- Seudah shelishit is the “in-between”/connection mode (described with kabbalistic language such as “relatable connection”).

D. Practical application for a Sukkot-first-day-on-shabbat year

- Rabbi Shulman suggests:
 - When lulav is absent due to shabbat constraints, the community can “replace” that avodah by focusing more intensely on the relevant dimension of shabbat—especially the “connection” mode associated with סעודה שלישית.
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IX. Practical community note and an open halachah/minhag clarification (33:04)

A. Seudah shelishit logistics when the next day is Yom Tov

- Rabbi Shulman notes a practical tension:
 - Eating late can be complicated when the following day is Yom Tov.
 - Singing and divrei Torah remain viable, and the group considers whether to make additional efforts.

B. A participant asks: what does it mean that not shaking is “a minhag”?

- Rabbi Shulman agrees to clarify the distinction between הלכה and מנהג afterward in a side conversation.

C. A final question is raised about comparing lulav to shofar (partial, ends mid-discussion)

- The transcript closes as participants probe whether the “replacement” logic parallels shofar (where one might still blow on the second day in some contexts), versus lulav (where the opportunity feels more fully lost in this case).
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X. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman uses the Mishnah’s “six and seven” framework to show how shabbat can suspend lulav depending on which day it falls.

- He explains how **מנהג אבותיכם בידיכם**—kept due to **ספיקא דיומא** in חוץ לארץ—can end up shaping practice even in ארץ ישראל.
- Beyond the technical fear of carrying, Rabbi Shulman frames lulav as spiritual “weaponry” and conflict, which can clash with shabbat’s essence of מנוחה—especially in גלות, where tranquility is already fragile.
- He presents a deeper principle: shabbat has its own inner spiritual structure (שבת/כלה/מלכה), mirrored in the three meals) that can substitute for the spiritual work that lulav would otherwise perform.